

A Brief Introduction of the October 25 Coup in Sudan

On Monday, the Sudanese military staged a military coup, placing several senior government officials, including Prime Minister Abdullah Hamdok, under house arrest, restricting Internet access, and taking over state television and major media outlets by the military. Later in the day, Army Lieutenant General Abdel Fattah Abdelrahman Burhan, former chairman of the Transitional Military Council and chairman of the Sovereignty Council, declared a state of emergency in Sudan and dissolved the transitional government and the Sovereignty Council. Burhan said he would hand over power to a new democratically elected government after elections are held in July 2023.

Following the coup, the AU, UN, EU, Arab League and the US all condemned the coup and expressed concern about the situation in Sudan. The U.S. expressed its condemnation in the first hours after the coup, with the Biden administration announcing the suspension of \$700 million worth of financial aid to Sudan that day and State Department spokesman Ned Price calling for the immediate release of arrested government officials and the restoration of the democratically elected government. He also said the U.S. government is "closely monitoring" the situation in Sudan, and "without delay" to take measures such as the resumption of sanctions to punish the coup plotters. UN Secretary-General Guterres also issued a statement on the same day strongly condemning the "ongoing military coup" in Sudan and all activities that could endanger the political transition and stability, calling on all parties in Sudan to start a dialogue to restore constitutional order and the transition process. UN High Commissioner for Human Rights Michelle Bachelet also condemned the coup, arguing that the military's actions threaten the Juba Peace Agreement and jeopardize the gains made in democracy and human rights in Sudan. The head of the United Nations Integrated Transition Assistance Mission in Sudan (UNITAMS), Mr. Peeters, issued a statement saying the arrests of the prime minister, government officials and other politicians were "unacceptable. On the same day, EU High Representative Joseph Borrell also issued a statement saying that the EU condemns the arrest of Prime Minister Hamdok and other government officials by the Sudanese military and calls on the Sudanese military to release them immediately, arguing that the military's actions are a betrayal of Sudanese public opinion. AU Chairman Faki Mohamed expressed his "deep disappointment" at the "current situation in Sudan" that morning, calling for the resumption of consultations between the military and the democratically elected government and the release of all arrested government officials. In addition, the Secretary-General of the League, Ahmed Aboul Gheit, also expressed his "deep concern" over the development of the situation in Sudan on the same day, calling on all parties to return to the constitutional track signed in August 2019.

In late 2018 and early 2019, mass demonstrations broke out in Sudan against the government of Omar al-Bashir. At the time, various anti-government forces, including political parties and organizations such as the Sudanese Professionals Association, the Anti-Repression Feminist Organization, the Sudanese Revolutionary Front, and the National Consensus Forces, formed a loose political coalition, the Alliance for Freedom and Change, to demand Bashir's ouster.

Ultimately, Omar al-Bashir, who had ruled Sudan for 30 years, was overthrown in April 2019 after the Sudanese military intervened by force. The Sudanese military then established a transitional military council to impose military rule. But after months of demonstrations and calls for a democratically elected government by the Sudanese people and the Alliance for Freedom and Change (AFC), the military was eventually forced to compromise and pledge to share power with AFC. After a series of clashes and consultations, on August 20, 2019, the Sovereign Council of Sudan was established, consisting of five representatives each from the TMC and AFC, and one neutral civilian, to act as head of state until democratic national elections are held in 2023. But political differences between the military and the democratically elected government have been evident, as well as between parties within the Alliance for Freedom and Change. It is estimated that there are about 80-100 political parties in Sudan, many of which oppose power-sharing with the military, while others want to expand the power of the democratically elected government under a power-sharing structure, and whatever the demands are, they call for a weakening of the military's power, which is undoubtedly one of the reasons for the military's discontent. In addition, as per the agreement reached in 2019, Burhan, who is currently the chairman of the Sovereignty Council, will step down next month and an elected government official designated by the Alliance for Freedom and Change will take over the position. With the new elected official as Sovereignty Council chairman, former President Bashir will be further held accountable for human rights violations, and a number of military officers who held key positions in the Bashir-era military, including Burhan, are likely to be implicated. In addition, Burhan is likely to be held accountable for the violent crackdown on peaceful demonstrators against the junta in June 2019 once he leaves office. In addition to human rights, senior Sudanese military officers have been repeatedly accused by Hamdok and other government officials of being involved in monopolizing the country's economy and fostering corruption. Burhan and senior Sudanese military officials have good reason to fear for their fate if they lose power, so it is likely that the coup was a desperate attempt to save themselves.

Months before the coup, discord between Burhan and the democratically elected government led by Hamdok was already quite evident. Senior Sudanese military officials have repeatedly and publicly criticized elected officials, while stressing that the military has no intention of seizing power and that criticism of elected officials is intended to promote peace and stability in Sudan. Since September, the Beja High Tribal Council, a group of several major tribes in northeastern Sudan represented by Sayed Tirik, has blockaded Port Sudan, demanding a higher share of mining and energy revenues for local governments in the northeast and the ouster of Prime Minister Hamdok. Port Sudan has been blockaded for more than a month now, and many parts of Sudan are already experiencing shortages of wheat, fuel and electricity due to the port blockade. The blockade of Port Sudan, the country's only major port for foreign trade, has exacerbated the country's economic and livelihood situation and fueled popular discontent with Hamdok's democratically elected government. Although the military has denied any involvement in the protests by tribes in the northeast, Sudanese public opinion widely believes that these activities are supported by the military. Last Saturday (Oct. 23), anti-government demonstrations erupted in Khartoum, Sudan's capital, to protest against the sharp rise in prices and deteriorating living conditions, with protesters criticizing

Hamdok's economic reform policies for worsening economic conditions, and the Sudanese military also believed to be behind the demonstrations.

Following the October 25 coup staged by the Sudanese military, Sudanese democrats from all walks of life widely condemned the coup and called on people to take to the streets in protest. Protesters clashed with the military and police in the streets of Khartoum, and more than 10 people have been shot dead and more than 140 injured as of the morning of October 27. The protests continue to fester, and the security situation in Sudan is not optimistic. In addition, the conflict between the Beja tribe in northeastern Sudan and the central government has not been eliminated, and the "Sudan Liberation Movement" led by Abdul Wahid Nur in Darfur and the "Northern Sudan People's Liberation Movement" led by Abdul Aziz Shinu in the Nuba Mountains "Even if Burhan succeeds in taking power, he is likely to be caught in multiple struggles with opponents within the army, supporters of the elected government and local opposition forces.

China currently has more than 130 enterprises operating in Sudan, covering a wide range of fields such as petrochemicals, infrastructure, agriculture, and medical care. At a time when the political situation in Sudan is becoming increasingly complicated, the risks of Chinese enterprises investing and operating in Sudan have increased dramatically. It is a matter of great urgency to establish communication channels as soon as possible to protect the lives and properties of enterprises and personnel in Sudan, and to minimize the losses caused by political security risks.

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